

Essential programs

There are a few programs that every computer needs in order to work. Some of the most important programs are operating systems, compilers, and interpreters.

SEE ALSO

◀ **180–181** Inside a computer

◀ **182–183** Binary and bases

◀ **188–189** Processors and memory

Operating system

The operating system (OS) is the manager of the computer's resources. It controls which programs are allowed to run, how long they run for, and which parts of the computer they use while running. The OS also provides interfaces, such as file browsers, to let a user interact with the computer. Common operating systems include Microsoft Windows and Mac OS X.

The operating system is like an octopus, with tentacles connecting to all parts of the computer

The operating system manages the processor's time

▷ How it works

The processor's time is divided up into slices. A program will be given a slice. If it can't finish in that time, it is paused and the next program runs.

